

Chapter 4

The Cost of Power

Monday mornings were never quiet at Northbridge Group.

By eight o'clock...

Every office was alive.

Phones rang endlessly.

Employees hurried through the hallways carrying files, laptops and hurried conversations.

From the floor-to-ceiling windows...

Frankfurt looked calm.

Inside the building...

Nothing was.

Emma knocked gently before entering Elara's office.

"Good morning, Miss Elara."

"Your father has asked you to join the board meeting."

Elara closed the file she had been reading.

"My first one?"

Emma smiled.

"He said it's time."

A few minutes later...

The boardroom doors opened.

Around the long wooden table sat directors, investors and senior executives.

Some had spent decades building companies.

Others had spent decades protecting them.

Elara quietly took her seat beside her father.

A large screen lit up.

Numbers.

Graphs.

Future projects.

Investment reports.

One presentation followed another.

Until...

One of the investors spoke.

"I don't think we should continue with the Riverside District Project."

"The financial risk is too high."

The room immediately filled with whispers.

Another director nodded.

"I agree."

For a few seconds...

Nobody spoke.

Then Elara's father slowly stood.

He didn't raise his voice.

He didn't argue.

Instead...

He asked one simple question.

"If everyone only invested where there was no risk..."

"Who would build tomorrow?"

Silence.

He looked around the room.

"Business isn't about avoiding problems."

"It's about solving them before everyone else."

He paused.

"Profit is the reward."

"Trust is the real investment."

The room became completely silent.

One by one...

The directors nodded.

Even the investor who had objected lowered his eyes.

The meeting continued.

An hour later...

It finally ended.

As everyone walked out...

Elara remained seated.

"I never realized business was like this."

Her father smiled.

"Most people think companies are built with money."

"They're built with decisions."

"One right decision can save thousands of jobs."

"One wrong decision can destroy thousands of families."

Elara looked at him quietly.

For the first time...

She understood that business wasn't only about buildings.

It was about people.

As they stepped into his office...

Another visitor was already waiting.

A senior government official.

The three exchanged greetings before discussing permits, infrastructure and public transport for an upcoming development project.

Elara listened quietly.

After the meeting ended...

She couldn't hide her curiosity.

"Dad..."

"Can I ask you something?"

He looked up from his desk.

"Of course."

"Why do politicians work so closely with companies?"

He smiled faintly.

"Because governments create laws..."

"But businesses create opportunities."

"A country grows when both remember they're working for the same people."

He handed her a file.

"Never forget that."

"Power isn't measured by how many people obey you."

"It's measured by how many people trust you."

Those words stayed with Elara.

As she left his office...

She couldn't stop thinking about them.

Back in her own office...

Emma entered carrying a thick blue folder.

"This just arrived from the archives."

"It belongs to one of our oldest projects."

Elara thanked her and placed it on her desk.

She opened the file without giving it much thought.

Old maps.

Contracts.

Construction plans.

Everything looked ordinary.

Until...

A folded piece of paper slipped from between the pages.

It wasn't part of the file.

Someone had placed it there.

She slowly unfolded it.

Only one sentence was written across the page.

"The truth is never buried... it only waits."

No name.

No signature.

Nothing else.

A cold breeze drifted through the slightly open window.

For the first time that day...

The office no longer felt peaceful.